Trust in the Lord with All Your Heart

True wisdom begins with trusting God rather than our own understanding, acknowledging him in all our ways, honouring him with what we have, and accepting his loving correction.

Main passage	Proverbs 3:1-12 (KJV)
Topic	Wisdom
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Keep God's teaching close to your heart	7 min
Teaching point 2: Trust God, not your own understanding	7 min
Teaching point 3: Honour God with your wealth and accept his correction	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "What is the best piece of advice anyone ever gave you?" Let several people share. Point out that the book of Proverbs is written as a father's advice to his son. Today's chapter contains some of the most-loved verses in the Bible: "Trust in the LORD with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own understanding."

Scripture (3 min)

Proverbs 3:1-12

[1] My son, forget not my law; but let thine heart keep my commandments: [2] For length of days, and long life, and peace, shall they add to thee. [3] Let not mercy and truth forsake thee: bind them about thy neck; write them upon the table of thine heart: [4] So shalt thou find favour and good understanding in the sight of God and man.

[5] Trust in the LORD with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own understanding. [6] In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct thy paths.

[7] Be not wise in thine own eyes: fear the LORD, and depart from evil. [8] It shall be health to thy navel, and marrow to thy bones. [9] Honour the LORD with thy substance, and with the firstfruits of all thine increase: [10] So shall thy barns be filled with plenty, and thy presses shall burst out with new wine.

[11] My son, despise not the chastening of the LORD; neither be weary of his correction: [12] For whom the LORD loveth he correcteth; even as a father the son in whom he delighteth.

Read the passage aloud. Ask the class to notice the pattern of command and promise: "do this … and God will do that."

Background (5 min)

Proverbs collects wise sayings, many from Solomon (1:1). Chapters 1-9 are longer speeches, each beginning "My son." Wisdom in Proverbs is not cleverness but skill in living well before God, and it begins with "the fear of the LORD" (1:7), a reverent trust in him.

Proverbs describes how life generally works in God's world; its promises are not guarantees for every circumstance. Verses 9-10, about full barns, state a real principle of God's blessing. But verses 11-12 immediately add that God's children also go through correction and hardship. The book of Job and the life of Jesus show that the righteous sometimes suffer.

Teacher note: Use verses 9-10 carefully. They teach generous, God-honouring use of money, not a formula for getting rich.

Teaching point 1: Keep God's teaching close to your heart (7 min)

The father urges his son not to forget his teaching, and to bind mercy and truth around his neck and write them on his heart (vv. 1-4). Wisdom is not just learned once; it is kept close, worn every day, and written inwardly until it shapes who we are.

Supporting verses

Proverbs 3:1-4: My son, forget not my law; but let thine heart keep my commandments: For length of days, and long life, and peace, shall they add to thee. Let not mercy and truth forsake thee: bind them about thy neck; write them upon the table of thine heart: So shalt thou find favour and good understanding in the sight of God and man.

Deuteronomy 6:6-7: And these words, which I command thee this day, shall be in thine heart: And thou shalt teach them diligently unto thy children, and shalt talk of them when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up.

Colossians 3:16: Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom; teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord.

> *"Let these be thy constant companions through life."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Proverbs 3:3

Handout blanks (answers)

Let not mercy and **truth** forsake thee.

Write them upon the table of thine **heart**.

Teaching point 2: Trust God, not your own understanding (7 min)

"Trust in the LORD with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own understanding. In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct thy paths" (vv. 5-6). We need not stop thinking; we stop leaning on our own thinking as if it were the final word. To "acknowledge him in all thy ways" is to bring God into every decision.

Supporting verses

Proverbs 3:5-8: Trust in the LORD with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own understanding. In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall direct thy paths. Be not wise in thine own eyes: fear the LORD, and depart from evil. It shall be health to thy navel, and marrow to thy bones.

Psalm 37:5: Commit thy way unto the LORD; trust also in him; and he shall bring it to pass.

Jeremiah 17:7-8: Blessed is the man that trusteth in the LORD, and whose hope the LORD is. For he shall be as a tree planted by the waters, and that spreadeth out her roots by the river, and shall not see when heat cometh, but her leaf shall be green; and shall not be careful in the year of drought, neither shall cease from yielding fruit.

> *"This is the center and marrow of true wisdom"*
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Proverbs 3:5

> *"Begin, continue, and end every work, purpose, and device, with God."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Proverbs 3:6

> *"There is not a greater enemy to the power of religion, and the fear of God in the heart, than conceitedness of our own wisdom."*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Proverbs 3:7-12

Handout blanks (answers)

Trust in the LORD with all thine heart; and lean not unto thine own **understanding**.

In all thy ways acknowledge him, and he shall **direct** thy paths.

Teaching point 3: Honour God with your wealth and accept his correction (7 min)

Wisdom reaches our wallets: "Honour the LORD with thy substance, and with the firstfruits" (v. 9). Giving God the first and best, not the leftovers, shows trust. Wisdom also reaches our hardships. God's discipline is

not a sign that he has abandoned us but that he loves us as a father loves his son (vv. 11-12; Hebrews 12:5-11).

Supporting verses

Proverbs 3:9-12: Honour the LORD with thy substance, and with the firstfruits of all thine increase: So shall thy barns be filled with plenty, and thy presses shall burst out with new wine. My son, despise not the chastening of the LORD; neither be weary of his correction: For whom the LORD loveth he correcteth; even as a father the son in whom he delighteth.

2 Corinthians 9:7: Every man according as he purposeth in his heart, so let him give; not grudgingly, or of necessity: for God loveth a cheerful giver.

Hebrews 12:5-11 (read from the Bible)

> *"To encourage thee to bear correction, know that it is a proof of God's love to thee"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Proverbs 3:12

Handout blanks (answers)

Honour the LORD with thy substance, and with the **firstfruits** of all thine increase.

Whom the LORD loveth he **correcteth**.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. What does it look like in practice to "lean not unto thine own understanding"?

Seeking God's word and counsel before deciding, being willing to be wrong, praying instead of just planning.

2. Why do you think conceit about our own wisdom is such an enemy of faith?

It makes God unnecessary; we stop listening, asking and trusting.

3. What is the difference between giving God the "firstfruits" and giving him what is left over?

Firstfruits is giving first, in trust, before we know if there will be enough; leftovers give God only what we did not need.

4. How can God's correction be a sign of his love?

A father who does not correct does not care; God's discipline shapes us into Christ's likeness.

Application (3 min)

Choose one decision you face this week. Before deciding, pray about it specifically, read a relevant Scripture, and ask a wise Christian for advice. Also review your giving: are you giving God the first, or what is left over?

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, we confess that we often lean on our own understanding. Teach us to trust you with all our hearts and to acknowledge you in all our ways. Help us honour you with our substance and receive your correction as the love of a Father. Direct our paths, through Jesus Christ, who is the wisdom of God. Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Proverbs 3:3

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Proverbs 3:5

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Proverbs 3:6

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Proverbs 3:7-12

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